

Historical geography: knowledge, in place and on the move

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I Introduction

Historical geographers have long been preoccupied with the subject of knowledge. Studies of the medieval farmer's understanding of the effects of soil nutrients on crop productivity, of the early modern cartographer's attempts to delineate some foreign coastline, or of the significance of climatological theory for late nineteenth-century imperial expansion – all have paid attention to the close relationships between knowledge, space and place. It would therefore be inaccurate to claim that the recent crop of books and papers addressing the historical geographies of knowledge are constitutive of a new field of inquiry. They do, however, reflect thorough-going connections between historical geography and other related disciplines – such as intellectual and urban history and the history of science – that have introduced some new subjects and approaches to the field of historical geography. It is also worth noting that many of the papers reviewed here were written by geographers but published in journals beyond the geographical discipline and so reflect a healthy two-way traffic, *out of* as well as *into* the field.

This report – the first of three by the author – will review recent works on the historical geographies of knowledge. It will

begin with a discussion of investigations into the production, circulation and consumption of knowledge as object – as words, text and image. It will move on to studies of knowledge shaped on the move – of bodies, travels and mappings – and then to knowledge in place, including studies of the historical geographies of antiquities and the city. It will close with a discussion of the place of theory in historical geographies of knowledge.

II Texts and their travels and travails

In his recent contribution to a special issue in the *British Journal for the History of Science* (one dedicated to the historical geographies of science) Livingstone (2005) draws attention to a number of ways of thinking spatially about scientific culture (see also Livingstone, 2003a; Naylor, 2005a). He focuses in particular on the geographies of scientific writing, conversation and authority, or in his words 'text, talk and testimony'. In relation to the first of these, Livingstone argues that the 'possibilities for bringing geographical scrutiny to bear on written texts of all sorts are extensive. The material sites of book production, the circulation networks through which mass print criss-crosses the globe, and the social spaces of book acquisition, for example, are all inherently spatial phenomena'

(Livingstone, 2005: 94). He adds to this the 'hermeneutic dimensions of textuality' and considers the geographies of writing and reading – the difference place makes to both the preparation and reception of scientific texts.

Historical geographers have made significant contributions to this field of inquiry. For instance, Ogborn (2004a) has recently examined the connections between geography and writing in his study of eighteenth-century writing masters and their illustration of geography texts. Ogborn demonstrates the importance of writing techniques and technologies in the making of geographical knowledges and in their political and commercial deployment in 1740s Britain. Livingstone (2003b) has also considered writing and reading communities, taking the example of Sir William Whitla's 1922 edition of Isaac Newton's treatise on the biblical books of Daniel and Revelation. In his examination of Whitla's use of Newton's eschatological writings to support early twentieth-century Protestantism in Northern Ireland, Livingstone demonstrates the construction and deployment of canonical texts in the formalization of traditions and the negotiation of scientific and theological identities. To the 'ways in which texts may be staged by partisans to achieve certain goals, to deliver to readers a hermeneutic steer on the reading of a document and to align the author with particular ideological interests' (Livingstone, 2003b: 28) Livingstone folds in what he terms 'distinctive regional geographies of reception' (p. 29) – that is, the ways texts' meanings and authorities change from place to place.

Finnegan (2004) develops a similar form of analysis in his consideration of the assessment, dissemination and reception of glaciological theory in early Victorian Edinburgh, Scotland. Finnegan outlines the ways 'people, institutions, publications and field practices were implicated in the promotion and consumption of glacial theory' (Finnegan, 2004: 30). Theories circulated through a variety of means – 'newspapers, correspondence

networks, lecture halls, science journals and field sites' (p. 31) – and following them there provides 'a unique account of the city's scientific endeavours to be given and help ground some better-known and some untold engagements with the geological theory in question' (Finnegan, 2004). Finnegan then, like Livingstone, assumes that any scientific theory cannot be fully understood simply by examining an author's treatise or even his or her detractors' counter-arguments, but that the theory must also be placed within its social contexts. This historiographical move dictates not only a temporal sensitivity to the development of ideas but a spatial one too. As Secord (2000) has famously shown in his exhaustive study of the Victorian publishing sensation, *Vestiges of the natural history of creation*, ideas change not only over time but across space too. Numbers and Stenhouse's (2001) edited collection *Disseminating Darwinism* provides a series of case studies that bear out the same point, namely that geography has a great bearing on the development, movement and reception of ideas.

Circulating knowledges are also central to papers by Mayhew, Withers and others. Mayhew (2005) attempts to map out the geographies of the early modern Republic of Letters by tracing the citations in two geography books: Peter Heylyn's 1621 *Microcosmus*, and John Pinkerton's *Modern geography* of 1802 (see also Mayhew, 2004). By looking at the 'spatial patterning of their reading' Mayhew works 'to gain a sense of the spatial extent of the imagined community of scholars with whom Heylyn in the early seventeenth century and Pinkerton in the first years of the nineteenth century were in intellectual dialogue' (Mayhew, 2005: 76). Mayhew's paper provides us with a novel approach to the geographies of scholars' 'imagined communities' in that attention to the locations of those authors cited in a text provides us with 'a window onto the predispositions of an author and as such onto their imagined community of scholarly interlocutors and the geography thereof' (p. 77). Withers (2004a)

examines the writing of George Chalmers' *Caledonia*, a historical and geographical description of Scotland. In particular he traces the networks of correspondence and letter-writing that Chalmers employed in his researches and so demonstrates the 'geographical 'making' of Scotland as a textual enterprise' (Withers, 2004a: 33). An edited collection by Cantor and Shuttleworth (2004) examines the contributions that nineteenth-century periodicals made to the dissemination of scientific knowledge, while Fyfe's (2004) book *Science and salvation* considers the role and impact of evangelical writers on popular understandings of science.

III Knowledge on the move

A number of recent papers have considered texts and images that have been produced to convey knowledge of travel. Dym (2004) analyses maps of Central America from 1821 to 1945 and shows that their preoccupations and uses changed markedly over the period. Those from the 1820s and 1830s plotted new state boundaries and surveyed the land for purposes of commercial development. With the advent of accurate maps by the late nineteenth century, travellers were less motivated to produce maps for general consideration and instead concentrated on 'personalized' maps that illuminated their own private concerns, whether scientific, pleasurable or otherwise. By the mid-twentieth century, travellers had largely given up on map production altogether.

Dym provides a well-argued and richly illustrated account of the mapping of Central America, demonstrating the centrality of maps to the travel account (see Withers, 2004b, for another excellent historical geography of a mapping project). She also complains that insufficient time has been given over to cartography in studies of travel narratives. Literary scholars concerned with the geographies of travelogues tend, she claims, to consider geography and topography as metaphors and representations only in their textual form: 'The imaginative geography

considered is a geography of words, not one of pictures or designs' (Dym, 2004: 342).

Guelke and Guelke's (2004) paper on eighteenth-century traveller-naturalists is a useful adjoiner to Dym's, as they too highlight lacunae in recent scholarship on the historical geographies of travelling knowledge. In their paper they provide a reassessment of Mary Louise Pratt's (1992) seminal analysis of the travel account's role in the production of imperial knowledge of the non-European world. Through a close reading of Pratt's chapter on South African travel writers and their own reading of four of the authors Pratt considers, they argue that she fails to 'analyse the landscape as an object of interest in its own right, people as social and economic agents making a living from its resources, or the political mechanisms of colonial rule itself' (Guelke and Guelke, 2004: 12). Guelke and Guelke suggest instead 'increased attention to empirical historical evidence', whether from the accounts under examination or from other source material (for a thoroughly revisionist history of western expansionism, see Hobson, 2004). Scott's (2003) paper gives support to some of Guelke and Guelke's concerns. Scott looks at Spanish constructions of geographical knowledges of early modern Peru and pays close attention to the metropolitan knowledges of the New World. She also highlights the ways these 'official' knowledges were routinely and regularly undermined by both colonizer and colonized and so shows 'how the agency of both groups gradually shaped local as well as metropolitan administrative visions of the [Peruvian] Viceroyalty' (Scott, 2003: 167; see also Padrón, 2004).

A number of other recent papers consider the movement of knowledge, although they are less preoccupied with texts and concern themselves rather with the travels and travails of bodies and other objects. For instance, a series of recent papers have considered the historical geographies of travel in and representations of the tropical world (Bowd and Clayton, 2003; Martins, 2004; Power and

Sidaway, 2004). Livingstone's (2004) paper on the Orientalist and biblical scholar William Robertson Smith is also concerned with overseas travel and knowledge of other peoples. However, where Guelke and Guelke were concerned to demonstrate the complex nature of European descriptions of indigenous South Africans, Livingstone illustrates the reshaping of western religious and cultural *self-understanding* that resulted from such encounters. Smith's 1880 excursion in the Arabian Hijaz led to a reinterpretation of the character of primordial Semitic kinship and of primitive ritual sacrifice, and so to a 'radical recasting of the nature of the fundamental institutions of Western religion' (Livingstone, 2004: 640). Here was a thinker who 'travelled to the Arabian world to engage self-critically in uncovering the sources of his own religious practices' (p. 654). Meanwhile, Fan (2003) seeks to correct prevalent understandings of travel, knowledge and empire by examining the labours of British naturalists in nineteenth-century China and so provides a fascinating study of science in an informal imperial context.

Lorimer and Spedding's recent paper (2005) also examines the connections between bodies on the move and the production of knowledge. Their study is of the Scottish Parallel Roads of Glen Roy, the famous site of geological controversy that had attracted the attention of many of the greats of Victorian science. Lorimer and Spedding trace the experiences of a young family in the 1950s who chose to combine their annual holiday with geographical fieldwork. The focus of their attention is not the family's own contribution to the vexed question of the Roads' origin, but 'the process, not the product, of work in the field' (Lorimer and Spedding, 2005: 19). Lorimer and Spedding follow the movements and domestic routines of the family of four – husband, wife, child and child's aunt – so as to reflect on the various spatialities of labours in the field: geographies of location, landscape, work and leisure, imagination, gender and identity.

They conclude that to 'write a historical geography of science is *explicitly* to present scientific knowledge and practice as phenomena that are made in place and shaped by spatial relationships' (p. 33).

Gagen (2004) provides a historical geography of moving bodies, in this instance those of America's early twentieth-century urban youth as they were encouraged to use playgrounds, parks, vacation schools, field days, pageants and parades. These displays of organized young bodies were patriotic spectacles, meant to demonstrate the positive effects of physical education programmes. However, Gagen argues that a focus on the symbolic aspect of American pre-war physical education misses the point. Rather, she suggests that the symbolic function of play and parades was secondary to the psychophysiological reconstitution of character and of nation; this transformation of individuals 'reconceived as a process attainable via the muscular conditioning of consciousness' (Gagen, 2004: 420).

Dritsas's (2005) paper, like many of those reviewed above, takes movement and knowledge-making as his theme. However, in his study of the 1858–64 African Zambesi Expedition he illustrates the role of travel in the making of Victorian natural history by concentrating on the objects collected on the way, in this case a small collection of freshwater mussels. Following specimens on the move, he argues, facilitates a better understanding of the ways diverse spaces become networked and of the processes by which unknown objects in uncharted territories can eventually become part of pre-established forms of knowing (on objects and the making of knowledge, see the excellent edited collection by de Chadarevian and Hopwood, 2004).

IV Knowledge in place

Recent historical geographies of knowledge have not only been concerned with issues of movement, travel, and bodily comportment; they have also focused on knowledge of and

in place. Staying with the subject of the history of science, Finnegan (2005) provides us with a study of the relationship between natural history and local civic culture in late Victorian Scotland. Museums, public lectures, bazaars and the construction of new buildings were all means by which natural history societies contributed to a larger narrative of urban progress and to the good of the commonweal (Finnegan, 2005). Naylor (2005b) also looks at the connections between science, place and notions of progress. In his discussion of the work of the nineteenth-century zoologist Jonathan Couch and his production of a regional fauna of the English county of Cornwall, Naylor highlights the moral and religious imperatives that undergirded such work. Exhaustive scientific study of nature in place, according to Couch, was the only proper way of securing a more general understanding of the natural world, of nature's value to human industry, and ultimately of nature's creator. Meanwhile, Evenden (2004) considers how fisheries' scientists 'established institutions, engaged metropolitan ideas and local knowledge, and worked out particular spatial practices to produce fisheries science in early 20th-century British Columbia', Canada (Evenden, 2004: 355). Evenden argues that fisheries' science demonstrated a localizing emphasis in that scientists sought to understand local patterns of the natural world, even if this investigation was conducted within wider social contexts.

As recent research has demonstrated the locatedness of science so too have scholars demonstrated the historical geographies of ancient history. A number of books and papers, many written by historical geographers, have investigated situated understandings of eighteenth- and nineteenth-century geology, antiquarianism and archaeology. Freeman's recent book (2004) – a partner to his earlier volume on the place of the railway in the Victorian imagination (Freeman, 1999) – provides a wide-ranging and beautifully illustrated account of the place of the

prehistoric in Victorian culture. Sweet (2004), MacGregor (2003) and Smiles (2003) have provided comprehensive studies of eighteenth-century antiquarianism, and Harvey (2003) and Naylor (2003) have conducted much more local analyses of antiquarianism (more generally, see Anderson *et al.*, 2003). Harvey examines the way studies of Avebury, England, and Newgrange, Ireland, over the early modern period contributed to broader notions of nationhood, while Naylor traces the connection between local field-cultures in nineteenth-century Cornwall and nascent ideas of Cornish celticity.

As scholars have provided recent studies of maps and map-making on the move, others have examined cartographies of place over a range of temporal settings. Lilley has published several recent papers that examine how the European city was known and understood in the medieval period. Lilley (2004a) outlines the way the medieval city was understood as a scaled-down world and so linked the city and cosmos in the medieval mind. He goes further to demonstrate the 'symbolic, mystical significance urban form had in the Middle Ages' through an examination of urban layout and the performance of religious processions (Lilley, 2004a: 296; see also Lilley, 2004b). A special issue of the *Journal of British Studies* takes a later period and one particular city – London – to consider the making of the modern metropolis (Mort and Ogborn, 2004). As one of the contributors, Ogborn (2004b) discusses John Gwynn's 1766 plans for the improvement of the Cities of Westminster and London. Ogborn uses Gwynn's ultimately unrealized *London and Westminster improved* to demonstrate 'a historically specific relationship between the production of urban space in Georgian London and the self-fashioning of those who would assume the right to represent the city, alter it, and speak to what it might become' (Ogborn, 2004b: 16; for a more general treatment of Georgian geographies, see the essays in Ogborn and Withers, 2004). Gilbert (2004) is concerned with a

much later period – the 1920s – but like Ogborn takes as his focus a particularly influential treatise on the transformation of London: the London Society's 1921 *London of the future*. Through a discussion of the Society and its publication Gilbert examines their attempt 'to chart a future for the city that could be represented as distinctive from other modern urbanisms' (Gilbert, 2004: 119). For studies of knowledge in place at more intimate scales, see for instance Tachibana *et al.* (2004) on the vogue for Japanese gardens in Edwardian England, Llewellyn (2004) on the changing architecture of the domestic kitchen from the 1920s to the 1940s, and Withers (2004c) on sites of memorialization and commemoration.

V Localizing historical geography

In the first of his three progress reviews, Holdsworth (2002) draws attention to a shift in approach by historical geographers (see also Holdsworth, 2003; 2004). In particular he argues that the cultural turn has been influential in turning historical geographers away from grand histories – Holdsworth cites the example of Meinig's *Shaping of America* series (1998; 1999; 2004) – towards thick descriptions and micro-studies. It is undeniably the case that many researchers in the field have embraced a more localist approach to their work, choosing to develop their arguments out of specific case studies. Think for instance of Gilbert's use of *London of the future* as an avenue onto broader questions of London's twentieth-century modernity, of the way Dritsas discusses international science through the lens of six freshwater mussels, or of Mayhew's focus on two geography texts as a way of opening out the early modern Republic of Letters. This apparent discomfort with sweeping grand histories of populations, continents or periods combines with an increased focus on mundane and everyday lives at the expense of those of the singular and exceptional. Lorimer (2003) and Lorimer and Spedding (2002) among other historical geographers have certainly called

for more histories of geography as popular practice. Feminist historians, postcolonial theorists and historians of popular culture have also made similar sorts of claims, influencing geographers as they have done so (for one recent example, see Monk, 2004).

We need to be careful here of course. While it may be fair to say that research into the histories and geographies of knowledge has undergone something of a shift in scale and preoccupation, such a claim is perhaps less true of work in economic and environmental historical geography (and I hope to come back to some of these themes in later progress reviews). What *is* striking when reviewing these papers – and perhaps this is a more universally held belief – is an antipathy to heavy theorizing. Guelke and Guelke's sustained criticism of Pratt's homogenization of imperial representations is only the most prominent example here. For instance, Gagen's paper takes issue with nonrepresentational theory, a set of arguments that promote greater attention to bodily movement and physical experience (see for instance Thrift, 2000; Thrift and Dewsbury, 2000; Dewsbury *et al.*, 2002; Lorimer, 2005, for a review of the literature). She draws attention to similarities between it and American physical education reform and so questions the political implications of the theory. Indeed, Gagen suggests that 'both symbolic and non-symbolic frameworks are limited in their insistence that they provide some firm ontological ground upon which a theory of subject formation rests' and chooses instead to 'historicize bodies' as a way of doing justice to the ways physical education reform produced socially useful subjects (Gagen, 2004: 423 and 424, respectively). Meanwhile, Lilley (2004b) criticizes the way in which geographers have been so preoccupied by poststructuralist and postmodern debates about modernity that they have allowed the development of 'caricatures' of the feudal and medieval worlds. As a counter to this he mobilizes the idea of 'cosmopolis' so as to give space to 'a more nuanced 'Middle Ages' in

geographical thought' (Lilley, 2004b: 682). Evenden's paper makes much more positive use of a range of theories that have become popular in cultural geography – that is 'actor-network theory' and in particular the work of Latour (1987). However, although he makes use of Latour's theories on the development and mobilization of scientific knowledge, he none the less seeks 'to qualify and ground Latour's approach and suggest opportunities for a historical geography of science sensitive to local context ...' (Evenden, 2004: 356).

Geographers have taken much from a range of fields in the humanities to help them think about knowledge in different historical-geographical contexts. However, it is encouraging to this author at least that fruitful theoretical ideas from philosophy, postcolonial theory, science studies, cultural history and so on are not allowed to overextend – are thoroughly situated and grounded within – the spaces and times they are being used to unpack. In turn it is good to see that historical-geographical approaches to the knowledge business are being circulated in journals beyond the geographical discipline, the most notable examples here being the two special issues referenced earlier, in the *Journal of British Studies* (Mort and Ogborn, 2004) and in the *British Journal for the History of Science* (Naylor, 2005a). As has been evidenced in this review, historical geographers have much to add to broader debates about the making, circulation and consumption of knowledge; about the ways in which knowledge operates across different scales and manifests itself in particular situations; and indeed, as we have seen, about how we might best conduct spatially attuned analyses. To misquote Livingstone (2005: 100) slightly, 'Attending to these questions, I suspect, will be crucial to constructing coherent and persuasive historical geographies of knowledge and practice'.

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